

ALIGILE

REDISCOVERING THE
SOUL OF AGILE



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*Rediscovering the Soul of Agile
through the
saying of Imam Ali (pbuh)*

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***In the Name of Allah,
the All-beneficent,
the All-merciful.***

Imam Ali (Peace be upon him) said
in Nahjul Balagha.

*“I will define Islam as none before
me: Islam is submission (taslīm),
submission is conviction (yaqīn),
conviction is verification (tasdīq),
verification is acknowledgment
(iqrār), acknowledgment is fulfillment
(adā’), and fulfillment is action
(‘amal)”*

*(Nahj al-Balagha — Peak of
Eloquence: Hadith #125)*

Introduction

For over two decades, the Agile Manifesto has been our guide. We've learned to value individuals over processes, collaboration over contracts. We've adopted Scrum, Kanban, and a dozen other frameworks. We attend stand-ups, we plan sprints, and we hold retrospectives. We are, by all accounts, "*doing Agile*."

But if we're honest, sometimes it feels like something is missing. Sometimes our stand-ups feel like robotic status reports. Our retrospectives can circle the same problems without a real change of

heart. We get so caught up in the ceremonies — the how of Agile — that we lose the connection to its spirit, its why. This is the world of “*zombie Agile*,” where teams go through the motions but the life is gone.

What if the next leap forward in agility isn't a new framework or a better tool, but a deeper philosophy? What if we could improve our ability to be Agile by focusing on the inner journey that leads to great work?

This is the proposal I want to share with you, a philosophy I call

Aligile. *The name is a fusion, born from the wisdom of Imam Ali and the principles of Agile.* It's not a replacement for Scrum or a rejection of the Manifesto. It is a lens, an inner compass designed to give our Agile practices a soul.

It's a call for continuous improvement to extend even to our **philosophies**, reminding us that no school of thought should be immune to growth.

The **Blueprint** for Inner Agility

The concept of Aligile is inspired by a powerful narration from Imam Ali (Peace be upon him), a paragon of wisdom and justice, on the nature of true, meaningful faith. He described a six-step journey that moves from a state of inner acceptance to one of consistent, righteous action. This isn't about religion; it's about a universal blueprint for human integrity and how belief translates into behavior. Let's explore this journey and see how it can breathe new life into our Agile practice.

Stage 1: Submission (Taslīm) — Beyond Just Agreeing

The journey begins with submission. In our world, this isn't about blind obedience. It's about a willing, wholehearted acceptance of a higher truth. For an Agile team, this is the moment we move past just agreeing with the Agile Manifesto and truly submit to its wisdom. It's the conscious act of letting go of ego — the ego that loves old command-and-control habits or resists customer feedback — and aligning ourselves with a better way of working together.

Aligile asks: *Has your team truly had its Taslīm moment?* Have you collectively submitted to the idea that transparency, collaboration, and responding to change are your fundamental truths?

Stage 2: Conviction (Yaqīn) – The Unshakable “Why”

Submission, once embraced, grows into deep conviction. This is the unshakeable belief in your heart that what you are doing matters. In Agile, this is the team's **shared purpose**. It's the certainty that the project has value, that serving the customer is a worthy goal, and that your teammates have your back. This conviction is the fuel that powers a team through difficult sprints and complex problems.

Aligile asks: *Does your team operate with Yaqīn?* Do they have a

core belief in the mission that transcends the daily tasks and drives their motivation from within?

Stage 3: **Verification** (Tasdīq) — Seeking Truth in Our Work

Conviction is powerful, but it must be tethered to reality. This stage is about seeking verification — affirming that our beliefs are true. This is the very essence of empiricism, the engine of Scrum. Our **Sprint Reviews** are not just demos; they are acts of Tasdīq. We are asking, *“Does this thing we built truly meet your needs?”* Our **retrospectives** are moments of verification where we honestly inspect our process and ask, *“Is*

our conviction that we're working effectively actually true?"

Aligile asks: *Are your team's ceremonies treated as truth-seeking events?* Do you use them to courageously verify your assumptions against hard evidence and honest feedback?

Stage 4: Acknowledgment (Iqrār) — The Power of a Public Promise

Once we have verified something to be true, we acknowledge it publicly. This moves our commitment from a private thought into the shared, communal space. In Agile, our Kanban board, our Sprint backlog, and our burn-down charts are all acts of Iqrār. They are public declarations of our intent, our progress, and our challenges. This isn't just "making work visible"; it's a public promise that builds trust and accountability.

Aligile asks: *Do you see your information radiators as a form of public acknowledgment?* Are they treated as a pact with your stakeholders and with each other?

Stage 5: **Fulfillment** (Adā')

— The Definition of “Done” with a Soul

Acknowledgment creates **responsibility**. Fulfillment is the act of discharging that responsibility. It's about honoring the promise you made. For an Agile team, this is the Definition of “**Done**”. The DoD isn't just a technical checklist; it is a pact of fulfillment. When a team member says, “This story is done,” they are making a statement of honor: *“I have fulfilled the obligations we all agreed to.”* This transforms quality

from a requirement into a matter of professional integrity.

Aligile asks: *Is your Definition of “Done” treated as an act of Adā’?* Is it a shared commitment to excellence that the team fulfills with pride?

Stage 6: Action (‘Amal) — The Final, Meaningful Result

The entire journey culminates in action. This is the consistent, valuable work that is the fruit of all the previous stages. In Agile, this is the valuable, working software we deliver at the end of each cycle.

This increment is not just an output; it is the living proof of the team's journey. It's the physical manifestation of their submission to shared values, their deep conviction, their honest verification, their public

acknowledgment, and their fulfilled promises.

Aligile teaches us: *Consistent, high-quality action (Amal) is impossible without the inner work.* A team that lacks conviction or avoids honest verification will never be able to produce great results sustainably.

The Path Forward

Agile is not a new set of rules to follow. It is a new way to see. It's a philosophy that invites us to look inward and build the character of our teams, not just manage their workflow. It offers a language to talk about the human side of agility — the trust, the belief, the integrity — that is often left unspoken.

The world of knowledge has always been enriched by weaving together threads of wisdom from different traditions. By drawing on a 1,400-year-old framework for ethical action, we are not abandoning our modern practices.

We are giving them the **depth**, **meaning**, and **soul** they desperately need to thrive in the decades to come.

Let this be the start of a new conversation. Let's look for **wisdom** in all its forms and have the courage to continuously improve not just what we do, but *who we are* when we do it.